



11-9-2021 MCS Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Rsj2JAcVZJ8
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Muncie Community Schools Board of Trustees Meeting Summary

Meeting Date: November 9, 2021

Entity: Muncie Community Schools (MCS) Board of Education

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting was called to order by Board President Williams, who explicitly identified the governing body and meeting proceedings.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Mr. Williams (Presiding Officer), Mr. Heater, Mr. Barnes Griffin, Mr. Irvin, Mr. Lowe.
 - **Absent:** Dr. O'Neill.
 - **Central Office Staff Present:** Dr. Steven Baule (Superintendent / Dr. K / Dr. Bryakowski), Mr. Brad Jerome (Chief Financial Officer / Director of Business), Dr. Jim Reynolds.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance led by several local elementary students: fifth grader Jeremiah Pounds, fourth grader Sam Kinzel, third grader Gretchen Gunter, second grader Braxton Juarez, first grader Lola Davis, and kindergartner Glenn Ingram.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** *(Not explicitly detailed in the transcript text beyond standard procedural progression).*
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:08:02 Westview Elementary School Presentation

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Eric Ambler, Principal at Westview Elementary.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Principal Ambler presented an overview of Westview Elementary, noting an enrollment increase to 424 students (including 7 virtual students, 310 regular education, and 114 in their one-way dual language Spanish immersion program). He highlighted community partnerships with Ball State University (reading, math, and special education practicums), Second Harvest food pantry, Westminster Presbyterian Church, and the Anthony Northside Neighborhood Association (six new raised garden beds). He also showcased a multi-sensory "ninja path" hallway designed to support social-emotional learning and student reset breaks. Ambler reported that the school's dual language immersion program was recently recognized as a "Distinguished Dual Language Immersion Program" by the Indiana Foreign Language Teachers Association. Board members discussed building capacity constraints, noting that Westview is currently at maximum capacity.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation; no formal board action required.

00:55:58 Consent Agenda (Personnel Report)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board Leadership / Administration.
- **Deliberation Summary:** The personnel report was presented, with the note that Mr. Knuckles withdrew his name from consideration for a School Resource Officer (SRO) position, removing him from the consent agenda. The board also recognized Anna Spencer for 20 years of service at South Side Middle School as she transitions to an administrator position at Winchester Community Schools.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

00:56:57 District Calendars (2022<U+2013>2023 & 2023<U+2013>2024)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. Jim Reynolds.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Dr. Reynolds presented a two-year district calendar covering the 2022<U+2013>2023 and 2023<U+2013>2024 school years, developed in collaboration with a stakeholder committee. The calendar maintains 180 student days, 185 teacher work days, a five-day fall break, a two-week winter break, a five-day spring break, and a one-day innovation summit. It includes fourth-Tuesday two-hour early release days (excluding March and December) and an additional early release day dedicated to parent-teacher conferences.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

01:03:30 Medical Insurance Plan Renewal for 2022

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brad Jerome, CFO.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Mr. Jerome recommended renewing the district's medical, dental, and vision insurance with Unified Group Services (UGS) for calendar year 2022. The renewal reflects a modest 1.5% premium increase for employees and the school corporation (equating to approximately \$13 annually for a single employee plan). Additionally, the district is introducing an alternative high-deductible health plan ("Plan B") linked to a Health Savings Account (HSA) to provide employee choice, with the district seeding \$500 for single plans and \$1,000 for family/plus-one plans. The total estimated cost increase to the corporation is approximately \$140,000, which was built into the 2022 budget.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

01:10:53 Food Service Equipment Upgrades (Permission to Advertise)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brad Jerome, CFO.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Mr. Jerome requested permission to advertise for bids to spend down excess funds in the district's food service account, as required by state and Department of Education school nutrition audits due to a positive fund balance. The plan involves upgrading food service equipment and facilities across the district, beginning with North Side, to comply with state nutrition guidelines.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

01:12:49 Administrator Wage Adjustments

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board Leadership / Brad Jerome.
- **Deliberation Summary:** The board considered wage adjustments for district administrators, matching the percentage increases previously provided to teachers and

staff earlier in the year (just over 3%). The wage increases are retroactive to July 1st of the 2021<U+2013>2022 school year.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

01:14:39 Policy Review: Reasonable Suspicion Drug Testing

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board Leadership / Administration.
- **Deliberation Summary:** The board reviewed a policy update regarding reasonable suspicion drug testing for staff, aligning MCS practices with standard employer policies across the state and recommendations from the Indiana chapter of public administration human resources directors. The board moved to waive the second reading.
- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote (Second reading waived).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:44:21 Jim Arnold:** Addressed the board regarding concerns that Critical Race Theory (CRT) might be taught under the guise of Social-Emotional Learning (SEL). He requested complete, unedited copies of the K-12 curriculum. Board members and the Superintendent responded that MCS does not teach CRT, affirmed their commitment to anti-retaliation protections for teachers who bring forward legitimate concerns, and agreed to provide the requested curriculum documentation and links.
- **01:24:43 Chris Hyatt:** Addressed the board regarding academic performance metrics from the Indiana Department of Education, citing ISTEP scores and student enrollment figures, expressing concern over student transfers out of the district and the associated financial impact. Board leadership responded by clarifying state funding context, historical receivership background, and ongoing academic improvement efforts.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Strategic Plan & Dashboard Report:** Superintendent Dr. Baule presented the annual strategic plan update and dashboard, reviewing the five pillars: (1) High-quality pre-K education (noting pre-K classrooms in every elementary school and rising quality ratings); (2) Recruitment, development, and retention of educational leaders (master/mentor teacher support, cultural competency equity teams, minority employment increases to 12.5%); (3) Student-centered teaching and active learning (device distribution, Schoology adoption, Fountas & Pinnell literacy curriculum implementation, and Project Lead The Way growth); (4) Social and emotional learning (MTSS framework); and (5) Family and community partnerships (\$7.5 million in philanthropic investments).

- **EWA Construction Update:** Mr. Jerome provided a brief update on the upcoming \$8 million ESSER-funded renovation at East Washington Academy (EWA) to add walls and eliminate open-concept classrooms. Construction management will utilize existing open spaces to phase the project without installing costly portable classrooms, with bids opening November 19 and work scheduled to begin during winter break.
- **Board Dialogue & Future Planning:** Board members discussed scheduling future work sessions or executive sessions for professional development regarding finance and curriculum, as well as reinstituting community stakeholder surveys using Google Forms to gather ongoing feedback.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned by Voice Vote.

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